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The Social Safety Net After Welfare Reform: Recent Developments and Consequences for Household Dynamics

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Abstract

The remarkable transformation of the American social safety net that began in the early 1990s has led to seismic shifts in who benefits and how. More than two decades later, how should these changes be judged? Expanding and updating prior influential reviews, we evaluate how the transformation of the safety net—broadly defined—has shaped economic and family dynamics within low-income households. Collectively, social safety net policies have expanded support for working poor parents quite dramatically, while the cash safety net for the nonworking poor has all but collapsed. Working poor families have come out ahead economically, with mounting evidence of positive long-term benefits for child health and development. At the same time, a substantial number of poor families have fallen through the cracks, disconnected from stable, adequate wage income and cash aid. A growing number report income so low that it can be tracked with indicators used to measure poverty in the developing world. Meanwhile, contrary to reformers' predictions, these changes have had little effect on marriage or unwed births. We call for a reinvigorated focus on the continued evolution of the social safety net and discuss ways in which a sociological perspective can enhance such work.



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INTRODUCTION

It is hard to overstate the magnitude of the change in the US social safety net since the 1990s. In 1996, the Personal Responsibility and Work Opportunity Reconciliation Act of 1996 (PRWORA) replaced the nation's cash welfare program, Aid to Families with Dependent Children (AFDC)—a program that many policymakers and taxpayers believed discouraged marriage, encouraged unwed births, and disincentivized work—with the more restrictive Temporary Assistance to Needy Families (TANF). Just prior, large increases in the value of what had been a tiny refundable tax credit for the working poor—the Earned Income Tax Credit (EITC)—ensured that families with children would no longer be poor as long as a parent worked full-time, year-round. While PRWORA brought restrictions on cash aid, the EITC began to reward work like never before. And in the years that immediately followed, single mothers left welfare for employment in droves (CBPP 2016).

During the 1990s, participation in another key social safety net program, food stamps, fell along with the TANF rolls (Figlio et al. 2000, Gleason et al. 2001, Klerman & Danielson 2011). But over the next 15 years, the fortunes of the two programs diverged sharply. Food stamp receipt grew steadily between 2001 and 2007, and in 2008 the program was revised with the express aim of reducing stigma and increasing eligibility among the working poor (USDA 2016a,b). The program, rebranded as SNAP (Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program), is now a vital part of the safety net. Not only is the program a crucial source of support for the working poor, it compensates in part for TANF's free-fall.

Our review updates and expands on prior influential Annual Reviews articles that documented the early effects of PRWORA (Corcoran et al. 2000, Danziger 2010, Lichter & Jayakody 2002, O'Connor 2000). We evaluate how TANF has shaped economic and family dynamics, not just immediately after its authorization in the 1990s, but beyond. We find that early trends in TANF only tell part of the story of PRWORA. Each year since PRWORA was passed has seen additional changes to TANF implementation in states. Yet to truly understand the ongoing consequences of welfare reform writ large, one must consider not just the transition from AFDC to TANF but changes in the entire bundle of cash and near-cash means-tested federal programs—including TANF, the EITC, and SNAP—that determine what resources are available to whom. We show that taken together, changes in these programs represent a profound shift from a need-based to a work-based safety net. Americans have traditionally held strong beliefs about who among the poor was deserving, beliefs that have shaped who gets relief and on what grounds (Ellwood 1988, Katz 2013). Now, work is a primary litmus test by which deservedness is judged.

In this review, we also deploy our expertise as family sociologists to consider a key claim that drove many of the changes to the safety net starting in the 1990s—the alleged link between welfare and family structure. Many proponents of welfare reform claimed that safety net programs were responsible for family breakdown, among other social ills (DeParle 2004, Murray 1984, Weaver 2000). If this view is correct, it stands to reason that changes in the safety net, particularly the demise of TANF, should have had the opposite effect. Throughout our review, we consider evidence for the impact of changes in the safety net on family dynamics, including marriage and unwed births.

We conclude with an assessment of whether the changes of the 1990s—along with the considerable evolution of these programs thereafter—have hurt or benefited the poor. In the case of PRWORA and the move from AFDC to TANF, we conclude that the policy is best understood not as a moment in time—a stroke of a pen—but a dynamic, one that has stripped more and more cash from the neediest Americans and delivered them to those whom society deems deserving—especially workers. Ironically, despite these changes, the program continues to be deeply unpopular. The advent of the modern EITC is further evidence of a shift from an emphasis on caring for the neediest Americans to providing a hand up to the working poor, as has the

evolution of SNAP (though SNAP also continues to play a vital role in the lives of the neediest Americans). Notably, unlike TANF, both the EITC and SNAP enjoy broad political support. In sum, the transformation of the safety net since the 1990s is a story of winners and losers.

Since 2000, research on the American social safety net has reflected this divide. One line of work has documented the advantages the new safety net has conferred on working poor families and their children, who are now eligible for a substantial sum from safety net programs like the EITC and SNAP that by and large were not available before. New research has shown that the benefits to parents and children are substantial, both in the short term and over time as child beneficiaries transition into adulthood. Meanwhile, as TANF has waned, so too has scholarly attention to the program even though its continued evolution has been nearly as dramatic as it was in the initial years. Only very recently has new scholarship revealed that an increasing number of low-income households are falling through the cracks of the work-based safety net, reporting cash incomes so low that scholars track them with metrics from the World Bank used to measure poverty in the developing world (Edin & Shaefer 2015). Despite recent methodological advances that use administrative data and exploit state-level policy change, we are only now beginning to learn about the fortunes of those who, over time, have proven to be the losers of welfare reform.

TANF: ENDING DEPENDENCY

The shift from AFDC to TANF was aimed primarily at ending long-term dependency on cash aid and, over time, its implementation at the state level redrew the boundaries of deservingness by rewarding the working poor at the expense of the neediest Americans. The notion of dependency among AFDC recipients was always a bit of a myth. A majority of AFDC households received benefits for less than two years (Bane & Ellwood 1983). Further, most combined work and welfare (albeit under the table) to meet their basic expenses, as welfare payments were low (Edin & Lein 1997). Yet dependency was how the problem was cast by politicians and how it was viewed by the public (Cherry 2007, DeParle 2004, Haskins 2007, Weaver 2000).

TANF was supposed to be a temporary source of cash assistance, a springboard to employment and self-sufficiency, and a way to bolster marriage and discourage nonmarital childbearing. It replaced AFDC, a federal entitlement program, with a time-limited benefit that was administered via block grants to states. It placed a lifetime limit of five years on benefit receipt, required significant shares of state caseloads to be involved in work activities, and offered incentives to reduce single and teen parenthood.¹ Other changes associated with PRWORA benefitted the working poor as well. Medicaid eligibility no longer automatically ceased when parents left welfare for work, and President Clinton successfully negotiated for increased federal funding for child care (DeParle 2004).

Researchers have used several empirical strategies to identify the effects of PRWORA on family and child well-being (see Blank 2002 for an extended discussion of these methodological points). Early evidence on the effects of the specific provisions that were ultimately included—time limits and work requirements—comes from a series of state-level randomized experiments during the late 1980s and early 1990s. During and immediately after welfare reform, researchers used panel surveys to track welfare leavers over time as they transitioned between the welfare rolls and employment after TANF authorization. After PRWORA's implementation, labor force participation among single mothers increased while TANF caseloads plummeted. For this reason, welfare reform was soon judged a success. But even during the economic boom of the 1990s,

¹ See Danziger (2010) for a comprehensive description of the legislative reforms of PRWORA.

scholars pointed to a growing number of single mothers who were disconnected from both work and welfare (see Danziger 2010 for a review).

Research on TANF fell off dramatically after the program was reauthorized in 2002. As a result, social scientists have largely neglected the continued evolution of TANF over the past decade or so. The share of poor families with children receiving cash welfare fell from 68% in 1996 to 40% in 2002, but that share has continued to fall, standing at just 23% by 2014 (CBPP 2016). Alongside this trend, recent research has revealed a sharp rise in the number of households reporting cash incomes so low that they can only be counted by indicators developed to capture destitution in the developing world—no more than \$2 per person per day (Edin & Shaefer 2015). Surprisingly, the time limits and work requirements of TANF seem to have played little role in the rise of this group, also referred to as the extreme poor. Yet the demise of TANF has seemed to play a critical role. When destitution strikes, fewer and fewer poor parents with children turn to TANF, even if eligible: TANF participation among eligible families has declined from more than 80% in the late 1980s to only approximately 30% today (ACF 2016).

Some scholars have charged that the block grant structure of TANF is partly to blame. Prior to PRWORA, all AFDC dollars not spent on administration went into the pockets of the needy. By 2014, states were spending only about one dollar in four of their federal block grant on cash assistance, and about one quarter on child care and work supports such as state EITCs, supports that benefit only workers. The remaining block grant funds have been diverted to other purposes that are even less likely to directly benefit the neediest Americans. Some states use the funds to plug state budget holes, such as shoring up child welfare coffers. In this case, TANF has become welfare for states, not people (Edin & Shaefer 2015). In sum, the TANF block grant has become a flexible funding stream for states, with more and more dollars diverted to the working poor and few reporting requirements or oversight by the federal government (Schott et al. 2015).

Because TANF block grants afforded states wide latitude in program design, recent research has used variation in state TANF policies to estimate the impact of PRWORA. The recent rise of large-scale administrative data sources also has allowed researchers to examine how TANF participation intersects with participation in other public programs and institutions. These empirical strategies have distinct advantages and weaknesses for identifying effects on family well-being, which we highlight below, but collectively they paint a picture of uneven economic fortunes following welfare reform, little impact on family formation and stability, little evidence of significant upward economic mobility for low-income parents, and potential costs and benefits to children that have emerged over time, depending on whether their parents ended up on the winning or the losing side of the ledger.

Economic Well-Being

Research during the immediate aftermath of welfare reform focused on the rising employment rate for single mothers, along with identifying a host of barriers to employment. The official employment rate for single mothers rose considerably in the years immediately following welfare reform, from 63.5% in 1996 to 72.8% by 2000 (CBPP 2016).² Despite these early shifts, the number of nonworking single mothers has grown steadily throughout the 2000s and now stands at levels higher than those prior to welfare reform (CBPP 2016). A growing share of single mothers

²Of course, many mothers receiving welfare were working before welfare reform (Edin & Lein 1997), albeit usually under the table, so some of the growth in employment was due to changes in what was reported to government officials rather than real increases in work activity—welfare reform’s so-called “smoke out” effect.

also became disconnected from both work and welfare at any given time (Blank & Kovak 2009, Danziger 2010). Early surveys of welfare leavers documented significant constraints that made it difficult to secure and maintain work, including mental and physical health problems, limited child care options, and transportation issues (Bloom et al. 2011, Turner et al. 2006). More recent qualitative research has documented the survival strategies families use to get by outside of the cash welfare system, after caseloads declined so precipitously: charities and relatives; selling food stamps, “scrapping,” and selling plasma for cash; informal jobs; and simply going without. Often, such families experience spells of homelessness or are unstably housed (Edin & Shaefer 2015, Seefeldt 2016, Seefeldt & Sandstrom 2015).

The average earnings of welfare leavers increased slightly during the 1990s, but this small average change masks considerable heterogeneity: approximately half of welfare leavers experienced an increase in income after leaving welfare, whereas the other half experienced a decrease in income (Moffitt 2001). The latter trend has brought a renewed focus on how the poorest households are faring. Since the 1990s, the number of children in deep poverty (<50% of the poverty line) and extreme poverty (<\$2.00 per person per day) more than doubled (Ben-Shalom et al. 2012, CBPP 2016, Fox et al. 2015, Shaefer et al. 2015).³ The poorest tenth of single mothers saw their total family incomes fall precipitously during the 1990s and have never recovered (CBPP 2016). Growing levels of extreme poverty can be found in virtually all large-scale surveys such as the Current Population Survey (CPS) and American Community Survey (ACS) and matched administrative and survey data from New York State, as well as in administrative records. In Maryland, a state with high-quality administrative records, more than one-third of TANF leavers have no earnings for an entire year (Nicoli 2015).⁴ And the number of families in SNAP administrative records with no cash income has more than quadrupled between 1995 and 2014, from approximately 300,000 to 1.3 million (USDA 2016a,b). Given this range of evidence, most researchers have concluded that families at the very bottom of the income distribution are worse off after welfare reform (Bitler & Hoynes 2016, Edin & Shaefer 2015, Moffitt 2015, Ziliak 2015), although considerable debate remains regarding exactly how much worse off they are, as Medicaid coverage expanded over this period.⁵

Although much remains to be learned about the short- and long-term consequences of the growth in deep and extreme poverty for family well-being, there are some troubling indicators that hardship might result. Food pantry utilization doubled between 1996 and 2013, barely budging since the recession of 2008. Although some groups, such as veterans, have seen dramatic declines in homelessness, child homelessness is also on the rise (Child Trends 2015). And rates of residential instability, food insecurity, and medical hardship are significantly higher among the extreme poor than among other families living below the poverty level (Shaefer et al. 2015).

The point-in-time and annual income and employment data used to document trends in work and income obscure the importance of temporal dynamics. Researchers who have used longitudinal survey or administrative data to track families over time have found that month-to-month household income volatility grew significantly for low-income families during the 1990s (Dynan et al. 2012, Western et al. 2016). This volatility is mostly due to unstable employment: Although

³These trends are mitigated somewhat when the Supplemental Poverty Measure (which accounts for all tax and transfer programs) is used, or when researchers account for the underreporting of government benefits (Fox et al. 2015).

⁴Although administrative data are not free of underreporting, it is a felony to hide income from the SNAP program, and reports are cross checked against Bureau of Labor Statistics and other records.

⁵If one examines trends in consumption rather than income, however, there has been little change in the consumption patterns of single mothers following welfare reform (Meyer & Sullivan 2004). The disjuncture between trends in income and trends in consumption may be partly due to rising debt loads among poor households that increased significantly during the 1990s and 2000s.

more than 70% of welfare leavers worked at some point during the first year after leaving welfare, only 4 in 10 worked consistently for the whole year (Acs & Loprest 2004). Similarly, most families who report extreme poverty in a given month have worked at some point in the past year (Edin & Shaefer 2015). These fine-grained temporal dynamics of work, income, and benefit receipt from month to month have led some to question whether disconnected workers are really a distinct subpopulation of the poor.

Family Dynamics

PRWORA sought to reduce dependency not only by requiring single mothers to work, but also by discouraging single parenthood and encouraging the formation and stability of two-parent families. Although the stated goals of welfare reform were to promote stable, married families and reduce nonmarital childbearing, the incentives PRWORA created for marriage and childbearing were ambiguous (Bitler et al. 2006, Grogger et al. 2002, Moffitt 2002). On the one hand, restrictions on cash benefits—such as work requirements, sanctions and time limits—could lead to more marriage by reducing women's economic independence. On the other hand, greater labor force participation and higher earnings disregards could lead to less marriage if they led to greater economic independence.

Perhaps because of this ambiguity, few studies find robust effects of welfare reform on family dynamics, and when effects are found they tend to be quite small in magnitude. Early studies typically focused on the marriage behavior and fertility of single mothers, using difference-in-differences analyses of national longitudinal surveys or vital statistics records to assess the effects of state-level variation in benefit generosity or family cap policies (described below), typically finding few robust effects (Blau & van der Klaauw 2013, Dunifon et al. 2009, Fitzgerald & Ribar 2004). Although there is little evidence of aggregate effects on the prevalence of marriage or single parenthood, researchers who have considered flows into and out of marriage using longitudinal data have found that more generous state-level policies may reduce the likelihood of divorce (Bitler et al. 2004), and potentially forestall the transition to marriage (Grogger et al. 2003, Teitler et al. 2009).

Research using similar methods has also found virtually no evidence that welfare reform influenced adult women's fertility—either from the generosity of state-level benefits or the implementation of a family cap that denies additional benefits for additional children born while receiving benefits (Dyer & Fairlie 2004, Grogger & Bronars 2001, Joyce et al. 2003, Kearney 2004). One family domain where there is consistent evidence that welfare reform had an impact, however, is the reduction in teenage childbearing (Hao & Cherlin 2004, 2007; Grogger & Karoly 2005; Kaestner et al. 2003; Kearney & Levine 2012; Lopoo & DeLeire 2006; Offner 2005), which has been attributed to policies that required teen parents to stay in school and live with responsible adults in exchange for benefits.

The sole study that found evidence that implementation of family caps reduced nonmarital childbearing also found, unexpectedly, that the family cap was associated with higher *marital* birth rates (Horvath-Rose et al. 2008). The authors acknowledged that this was implausible, and they suggested that endogeneity is a more plausible explanation—that features of state policies and state populations correlated with higher birth rates are also correlated with the implementation of family cap policies. This raises a more general concern with the use of state-level policy variation to identify effects of welfare reform—many other aspects of state policies, populations, and economies were changing during the 1990s and 2000s. If these are not accounted for, it may bias the conclusions of this body of research on how welfare reform shaped family formation behaviors.

States were permitted to use TANF block grant dollars to fund relationship and marriage education programs, and in 2001 the Administration of Children and Families (ACF) launched the Healthy Marriage Initiative and the Building Strong Families (BSF) program, which offered

sessions on relationship skills education to poor expecting or new parents who were unmarried. BSF was evaluated experimentally in eight study sites, and the final five-year evaluation revealed no improvement in couple relationships, coparenting, father involvement, or relationship stability or marriage, though there were some positive effects in one site and negative effects at another. One subgroup, African Americans, benefitted modestly. Over time, the negative effects faded, and the positive effects at one site—the probability of living continually with one’s partner and child—persisted (Wood et al. 2014).

Much of the work on PRWORA has taken a rather simplistic view of household structure, however, focusing disproportionately on marriage. The handful of studies that have included a broader view of living arrangements other than marriage offer some nuance to the general null findings. For example, researchers using state-level variation in TANF implementation and generosity have found increases in *both* the likelihood that children live with two parents (regardless of marital status) (Acs & Nelson 2004, Moffitt et al. 2015) *and* the likelihood that children live with neither parent (Bitler et al. 2006). More recently, researchers have also acknowledged that earlier work on welfare reform and family dynamics may not have focused on the most salient aspects of state-level policies, which actually hinge less on marriage and coresidence than they do on the biological relationships between resident fathers and their children (Lopoo & Raissian 2014, Moffitt et al. 2015).

Child Outcomes

Early research on the effects of welfare reform focused on how shifting low-income single mothers into the workforce affected children (see Brooks-Gunn et al. 2010 for a review). Experimental evaluations of the waivers prior to welfare reform found little effect of maternal employment alone on children’s outcomes, but significant gains in child achievement and behavior when mothers received EITC-like earnings supplements. The waiver experiments also found different effects by child age, with young children experiencing neutral or positive effects but adolescents sometimes experiencing worse achievement and behavioral outcomes (see Danziger 2010 for a review of these early studies). Similarly, studies of welfare leavers identified few substantial consequences for child well-being in the first few years after welfare reform (see Danziger 2010). One important caveat to this is that nonexperimental studies have found that unstable maternal employment after leaving welfare is associated with worse academic performance and behavioral outcomes among teenagers in particular (Chase-Lansdale et al. 2003, Gennetian et al. 2008, Johnson et al. 2010, Kalil & Ziol-Guest 2005).

More recently, researchers have recognized that welfare reform interacted with changes in other government programs, redefining access and eligibility with implications for contact with other government agencies. Families who receive AFDC and TANF are categorically eligible for Medicaid, and, as mentioned earlier, welfare reform took steps to delink Medicaid eligibility from TANF so that mothers would not lose medical care when they left the welfare rolls. Nonetheless, when families left the welfare rolls, it led to lower health insurance coverage, less health care utilization, and less prenatal care (Cawley et al. 2006, Kaestner & Kaushal 2003, Kaestner & Lee 2005). These reductions in health insurance coverage and health care utilization were associated with significant increases in the incidence of low birth weight and significant reductions in the rate of breastfeeding (Haider et al. 2003, Kaestner & Lee 2005). These results, of course, predate subsequent expansions in health care coverage under the Affordable Care Act in 2009.⁶

⁶An emerging body of research is beginning to examine the consequences of the Affordable Care Act and Medicaid expansions for insurance rates, health care utilization, and health-related outcomes among the poor (Sommers et al. 2015).

Welfare reform has also shaped families' contact with the child welfare system. Analyses of both randomized experiments and state-level policy variation suggest that welfare reform may increase the number of children in the foster care system (Bitler et al. 2006, Fein & Lee 2003, Paxson & Waldfogel 2003), driven by reductions in benefits, family caps, and tougher sanctions (Waldfogel 2004). These analyses, which only cover the early years of welfare reform's implementation, are complemented by a recent study by Shaefer and colleagues (2016), which found that within states, caseload declines subsequent to welfare reform were associated with increases in the incidence of child homelessness.

Few studies have examined the effects of PRWORA on children's long-term outcomes into adulthood, which we view as a central avenue for future research. A handful of studies have used survey and administrative data to examine the consequences of both state- and national-level policy changes on teenagers' educational attainment and find significant reductions in school dropout, improved test scores, and increases in years of schooling, with particularly large effects for girls (Dave et al. 2012; Kaestner et al. 2003; Miller & Zhang 2009, 2012; Offner 2005). Importantly, these long-term findings stand in contrast to the earlier generation of welfare waiver and welfare leaver studies that found adverse effects for teenagers. Several of the more recent studies also help reconcile these divergent findings by showing that positive effects did not emerge immediately following the implementation of policy change (Hao & Cherlin 2004) but evolved over a longer period of time postreform (Miller & Zhang 2009, 2012).

Sociopolitical Outcomes

One might predict that the dramatic reforms that ended entitlements, required work, and placed time limits would improve the public perception of welfare. This does not appear to be the case: Americans' perceptions of welfare programs are quite negative, and this changed little after welfare reform. In 1989, 64% of respondents in public opinion polls thought "welfare benefits make poor people dependent and encourage them to stay poor"; by 2003, 71% supported this statement (Soss & Schram 2007, p. 115). Negative perceptions of welfare are also prevalent among current and former recipients themselves; although they often point to poor luck and personal hardships to explain their own spells of participation, recipients invoke popular stereotypes about laziness and lack of motivation to explain the participation spells of others (Halpern-Meekin et al. 2015, Secombe et al. 1998). Welfare reform may have led current or former recipients to exercise their political voice, however. Using state-level variation in welfare policies, researchers have found that state-level implementation of AFDC waivers or TANF was associated with a 10% increase in voting among single mothers (Dave et al. 2016), although the researchers did not consider the effects of other policy changes during that period, such as state EITC expansions.

Although research on TANF tapered off after the program was reauthorized in 2002, the program has continued to evolve in ways that shift resources from the nonworking to the working poor, and many questions remain about its consequences for families. First, there are hints of a growing bifurcation among the poor, marked by the emergence of a class of families living in extreme poverty, but we are just starting to learn how such extreme poverty shapes family functioning and well-being. Second, research on the effects of welfare reform for children tended to focus on short-term consequences of welfare and employment transitions; we know less about the longer term effects of this income volatility for children. The cohort of children exposed to welfare reform are now transitioning to adulthood, and important questions remain about whether and how welfare reform altered the reproduction of disadvantage among the children of welfare reform.

SNAP: DESTIGMATIZATION & DESERVINGNESS

Unlike the declining role of TANF in the American social safety net, the importance of the food stamp program (renamed SNAP in 2008) has soared in recent decades.⁷ Like any good safety net, SNAP participation is countercyclical—the rolls grow during recessions as incomes fall and they decline during periods of economic expansion (Bitler & Hoynes 2010, Ganong & Liebman 2013, Klerman & Danielson 2011, Ziliak et al. 2003). The food stamp program was also a target of PRWORA. As part of the PRWORA legislation, time limits were placed on food stamp receipt for able-bodied adults without dependents—called ABAWDS by the US Department of Agriculture (USDA), which administers the program—who were not working. Legal immigrants were also banned from the food stamp program until they became citizens, and states were required to shift from paper stamp coupons to electronic benefits cards (Gleason et al. 2001). Because AFDC/TANF recipients were categorically eligible for food stamps, the decline in TANF caseloads after welfare reform also resulted in reductions in food stamp participation initially (Ziliak et al. 2003). Between welfare reform and a strong economy that pulled more adults into the labor force in the 1990s than at any time in modern history, food stamp participation rates fell precipitously—by 40%—during the 1990s (Figlio et al. 2000, Gleason et al. 2001, Klerman & Danielson 2011).

That trend reversed during the 2000s. Participation rates rose steadily during the early 2000s, before skyrocketing during the 2008 recession. Most of this growth was due to macroeconomic conditions, but program changes in the 2002 and 2008 Farm Bills and 2009 American Recovery and Reinvestment Act (ARRA) also played a role (Ziliak 2016). The 2002 bill restored eligibility to legal permanent residents with at least 5 years of residency, liberalized and simplified asset tests, aligned income and eligibility standards with other means-tested programs, and simplified reporting and recertification aimed at improving payment accuracy. The 2008 bill increased benefit generosity and expanded eligibility, offered funding for healthy food incentives, and aimed to combat stigma by changing the program name to the Supplemental Nutrition Assistance Program. Benefits were expanded again during ARRA in 2009 in the wake of the recession, raising minimum benefit levels and removing the time limits for able-bodied adults without dependents. These expansions were temporary, however, and expired in 2013. In the 2014 Farm Bill, Congress cut SNAP funding and ended categorical eligibility for individuals who qualify for SNAP via their participation in other government programs like TANF or Medicaid. These changes, along with economic growth, have led to modest reductions in participation and benefit levels for households in recent years (USDA 2016a,b).

Economic Well-Being

SNAP's most direct and immediate benefit is alleviating food insecurity in poor households. One empirical strategy for assessing SNAP is to use temporal and geographic variation in benefit eligibility and generosity to estimate the impact of the program. Researchers using this approach have found that SNAP receipt boosts household expenditures on food and reduces the incidence of household food insecurity (measured as lacking resources for consistent access to food) by approximately 30% (Blundell & Pistaferri 2003, Mykerezi & Mills 2010, Ratcliffe et al. 2011).

⁷Households with incomes less than 130% of the federal poverty line are eligible for SNAP benefits and all AFDC/TANF participants are categorically eligible for SNAP, with maximum benefit values determined based on the price of the USDA's Thrifty Food Plan. The maximum benefit amount is reduced by 30 cents for every dollar of household income, a reduction rate based on the expectation that a household should contribute 30% of their own income to food.

A second empirical strategy for assessing SNAP impacts is to compare SNAP households who recently joined the program (but have not yet received benefits) to SNAP households who have participated in the program for a period of time. Researchers adopting this approach have found similarly large effects of SNAP receipt on household food expenditures and food security (Li et al. 2014, Mabli & Ohls 2015, Mabli & Worthington 2014). Several studies have also compared the nutritional intake of SNAP and non-SNAP recipients, finding that SNAP is associated with better nutrition (Basiotis et al. 1998, Devaney & Moffitt 1991, Rose 1999). Despite these benefits, SNAP benefits are typically exhausted before the end of the month, and a large share of low-income families remain food insecure even after receiving benefits (Castner & Henke 2011, Hastings & Washington 2010, Todd 2014).

If we count SNAP as if it is cash income, SNAP lifts a significant number of Americans out poverty. By this measure, in 2014, 4.7 million people were boosted out poverty because they were SNAP recipients (Short 2015). Shaefer & Edin (2013) estimate that, when counted as cash, SNAP halved the number of households living in extreme poverty. These estimates, derived from household surveys, are conservative, because there is widespread underreporting of benefit receipt in the household surveys typically used to simulate anti-poverty effects—although the Survey of Income and Program Participation tends to perform considerably better than the CPS or ACS (Meyer & Mittag 2015). Social scientists have developed microsimulation tools that can correct for such underreporting. In light of these limitations, some have advocated for consumption-based measures of well-being instead of income-based measures (Meyer & Sullivan 2012).

Like many means-tested programs, increases in SNAP reduce employment and work intensity by a small amount; historical analyses suggest that the program's introduction reduced single mothers' work intensity by approximately 20 days per year (Hoynes & Schanzenbach 2012). Yet, as with TANF, the share of nondisabled, working-age SNAP recipients who are in the labor force has grown steadily over time, reaching just over 50% in 2012 (Rosenbaum 2013). This is in part due to work requirements that have been instituted in some states (USDA 2016a,b), declining stigma (DeParle & Gebeloff 2009), and stagnating low wages that keep households in poverty even when working (BLS 2015).

Family and Child Well-Being

Marital status is not considered in the determination of SNAP benefits (Maag & Acs 2015). Instead, all household members who share food expenses are counted in the benefit determination, including unmarried cohabiting partners and extended family members. As a result, SNAP is expected to have little effect on decisions to marry or divorce. To our knowledge, no study has examined the effects of SNAP on other aspects of living arrangements or childbearing.

SNAP does have significant health benefits, however, by reducing food insecurity and freeing up household income for other purposes (Hoynes & Schanzenbach 2015). For example, an analysis using state-level policy variation found that SNAP generosity was associated with better self-reported health, more checkups, and fewer sick days and hospital visits (Gregory & Deb 2015). Among children, SNAP receipt is associated with higher birth weights and less infant mortality, fewer hospitalizations, and better parent reports of child health (Almond et al. 2010). Although obesity levels are high among SNAP recipients, most careful studies that attempt to address measurement reporting error and other differences between recipients and nonrecipients find no short-term impact on obesity (Almada et al. 2016, Kreider et al. 2012) and possibly even long-run reductions in obesity for children (Almond et al. 2010, Hoynes et al. 2016).

Researchers have also used the fact that SNAP benefits tend to run out before the end of the month to examine impacts on dimensions of child development. Students performed worse

on standardized tests when the tests happened during the last week of the benefit cycle, when most families' benefits have run out, and students received more disciplinary actions during those times as well, suggesting that student learning and concentration was potentially affected by food insecurity (Gennetian et al. 2015). Researchers have also used variation in the timing and geography of the implementation of the food stamp program to examine the long-term effects of the program. Participation in the food stamp program as a child appears to having lasting economic benefits into adulthood, in the form of higher education attainment, more earnings, and less public assistance receipt (Hoynes et al. 2016).

Unlike TANF, if anything there is less stigma associated with the food stamp program since the 1990s (DeParle 2009). Both Republican and Democratic administrations have approved expansions (the most significant of these, the two Farm Bill changes discussed above, occurred during the Bush administration). The ranks of Americans who receive SNAP benefits is high—approximately half of all Americans have received them at some point during the course of childhood (Rank & Hirschl 2009). The program was renamed to highlight its role in promoting nutrition, and federal funds were used for outreach designed to further boost enrollment. It has also become more closely tied to the working poor, who in the United States are often deemed more deserving of government aid than those who do not work (Ellwood 1988). Debate over whether the government should regulate the types of food bought with SNAP dollars continues, however. In recent years, some cities have attempted to prohibit the purchase of sugar-sweetened beverages with SNAP funds (Barnhill 2011). Time limits and work requirements have been added for ABAWDS, and some politicians have advocated for adding these requirements for all SNAP recipients, including households with children.

SNAP participation is associated with a range of short-term benefits for family health and child well-being, and emerging research suggests that these benefits accrue over time and translate into long-term gains in socioeconomic status and health. Despite these positive effects, benefits are still not generous enough to get families through the month; this empirical fact is so pervasive that researchers have developed research designs around it. We know little about how families make food allocations or what coping strategies they adopt during that time (USDA 2013). We also know little about how the spread of time limits and work requirements into the SNAP program has affected those who are unstably attached to the work force. And although there are signs that SNAP has become less stigmatized and easier to access, there is ongoing debate about the costs and benefits of altering food diets by incentivizing health purchases or by restricting unhealthy purchases.

EITC: MAKING WORK PAY

The EITC has supplanted TANF as the largest means-tested cash assistance program in the United States. In 1975, the EITC was enacted as a small tax credit that refunded social security taxes paid by low-income workers with children. It was expanded considerably in the Tax Reform Act of 1986 and in the Omnibus Budget Reconciliation Acts of 1990 and 1993. The EITC expansion in 1993, phased in between 1994 and 1996, was based on President Clinton's promise to make work pay: If you work, you should not be poor. Since then, many states have implemented their own EITC programs—usually funded by their TANF block grant—that provide an additional refundable credit on top of the federal program. In 2015, more than 27 million tax filers received approximately \$67 billion from the federal EITC, lifting 9.4 million out of poverty, including about 5 million children (IRS 2017). In comparison, just 1.1 million adults and 2.8 million children received TANF that year (ACF 2016). The vast majority of research on the EITC has used federal and state-level expansions in EITC generosity to identify the effects of the EITC on employment, family, and child well-being outcomes.

The EITC has reimagined the way the United States provides economic support to disadvantaged families. Its structure is radically different than any other means-tested program: You only qualify if you work, and your refund amount actually increases as you earn more, up to a point (approximately \$20,000 per year in 2015). This structure was designed to encourage and supplement low-wage work, and it has largely achieved this goal. Using difference-in-differences analyses of federal and state policy change, researchers have consistently found that EITC expansions were associated with increased entry into the labor force among single mothers, the group most likely to be eligible for the EITC (for a review, see Eissa & Hoynes 2006).⁸ This finding echoes the results of the early welfare waiver experiments, which found that earnings supplements boosted labor supply. The sole group for whom the labor supply effect of the EITC appears to be negative is so-called secondary earners (the person who makes less, typically the wife) in married families, who have greater flexibility in their employment decisions because their households are not solely dependent on their earnings (Dickert et al. 1995; Eissa & Hoynes 2004, 2006; Ellwood 2000).

Marriage & Childbearing

EITC benefits are calculated on the basis of tax filing status, and the policy has been criticized for creating disincentives for marriage because both members of a cohabiting couple can claim the benefit without consideration of their partner's income, whereas married couples cannot (though only one can claim a shared child as a dependent). The magnitude of the marriage disincentive depends on the employment of each partner, with the strongest penalties when both partners worked before marriage and at least one partner had a child. Despite these potentially large disincentives, most studies using state- and federal-level policy change find no meaningful effect of the EITC on marriage and divorce rates overall (Dickert-Conlin & Houser 2002, Ellwood 2000, Herbst 2011), though Eissa & Hoynes (2004) found that EITC expansions increased marriage among low-income families but decreased marriage among moderate-income families eligible for the credit.

Although a small EITC exists for childless tax filers, the credit amounts are substantially larger for households with children. This, combined with other refundable tax credits and deductions for having children and child-related expenses, has led some to consider the EITC a pronatalist policy (Lopoo & Raissian 2012). There is little evidence that the EITC induces childbearing, however, with most studies using state- and federal-level policy change reporting either no or very small effects (Alm & Whittington 2003, Baughman & Dickert-Conlin 2007). Other researchers have shown somewhat larger fertility effects for the entire income tax system, given the many tax incentives for having children, such as the child tax credit and dependent deductions (Whittington et al. 1990, but see Crump et al. 2011).

Family & Child Well-Being

More recently, a second wave of EITC research has shown that EITC expansions have had positive effects for children. Mothers who benefitted from EITC expansions have better prenatal health and fewer low-birth-weight babies (Hoynes et al. 2015, Strully et al. 2010). School-aged children in households that received more generous state or federal EITCs have higher

⁸The literature suggests that EITC expansions influenced changes in labor supply primarily on the extensive margin—the decision to work at all; there is little evidence that EITC expansions influenced work effort among those already in the labor market (Eissa & Liebman 1996, Meyer & Rosenbaum 2000, Rothstein 2010).

educational achievement (Dahl & Lochner 2012) and higher rates of college attendance and graduation (Bastian & Micheltore 2016, Chetty et al. 2011). Research into the mechanisms by which the EITC improves outcomes for children has identified boosts in parental expenditures on children, reductions in economic insecurity, and improvements in parental mental health and well-being (Averett & Wang 2016, Chase-Lansdale et al. 2011). For example, survey and qualitative research shows that most refund dollars are spent paying off debt and purchasing consumer durables such as cars and appliances, and other basic household necessities; smaller amounts of the refund are saved or spent on extras (Barrow & McGranahan 2000, Goodman-Bacon & McGranahan 2008, Halpern-Meekin et al. 2015, Smeeding et al. 2000). The EITC also improves parental well-being. For example, pregnant women who received the EITC were less likely to smoke, received more prenatal care, and reported better health than similar women who did not receive the EITC during pregnancy (Evans & Garthwaite 2014, Strully et al. 2010).

Sociopolitical Outcomes

The EITC has received broad bipartisan support—it has been expanded in the past during both Republican and Democratic administrations, and new proposed expansions have been put forth on both sides of the aisle. Adults who receive the EITC also find it socially incorporating: They say it rewards their hard work and supports them as they raise their children, with little of the stigma that they have felt in other means-tested forms of assistance (Sykes et al. 2015). The EITC is one of many forms of redistribution offered via tax policies, which primarily benefit middle-class and wealthy Americans. Political scientists have argued that such tax expenditures are an invisible source of redistribution, partly because they do not need to be approved by Congress each year and are thus less susceptible to being cut, but also because the individuals who receive benefits via tax expenditures do not feel as though they are getting help from the government (Howard 1997, Mettler 2011, Soss 2002).

SYNTHESIS: RECENT DEVELOPMENTS AND FUTURE DIRECTIONS

To truly understand the consequences of the recent transformation of the safety net for families and children, one must consider the entire bundle of cash and near-cash means-tested federal programs. A focus on TANF suggests the dwindling of the American safety net, but a broader view reveals that the United States now spends significantly more on behalf of the poor and near-poor than it did prior to welfare reform more than two decades ago. Who gets what from the safety net has shifted dramatically, with the majority of cash assistance dollars now going to those who are working (Scholz et al. 2009). TANF is conditioned on work effort, the EITC explicitly rewards low-wage work, and SNAP has expanded to incorporate more workers than ever before. Meanwhile, cash support to the neediest Americans—those without income from work—has fallen dramatically. In many states, the cash safety net for the nonworking poor is virtually nonexistent. Even in the most generous states, it is a shadow of its former self. Collectively, the transformation of these programs has redrawn the lines of deservingness in the contemporary American welfare state, placing primary emphasis on work as a condition of cash relief.

How have poor families and children fared in the wake of this dramatic and ongoing revolution in cash support? Contrary to the fears of some welfare reform critics, single mothers' entry into the labor force has had few measurable adverse effects on children. Although there were signs of negative short-term consequences for teenagers in the early welfare waiver experiments, these negative effects have not been borne out over the long-term, at least for those outcomes researchers have studied: educational attainment and teen childbearing. Instead, rising household incomes

from employment, plus transfers from SNAP and EITC, have had numerous benefits for children, improving health, school achievement, and potentially long-term educational attainment. We are still learning about the precise mechanisms that produce such benefits, but parenting behavior, expenditures on children, and access to higher-quality child care options are a few hypotheses. Exploring such family-level processes and mechanisms is an important task for future research.

Despite its effects on work and income, the transformed safety net has had little impact on family formation and stability, at least in the ways researchers have traditionally measured these dynamics. TANF's sharp decline, EITC expansions, and growing access to in-kind benefits such as SNAP have had little influence on marriage or on nonmarital fertility. This work has placed an inordinate amount of attention on marriage dynamics, however, and given the national decline in marriage rates over the past half century, future research should consider how the safety net shapes other types of household dynamics, especially the formation and stability of cohabiting unions. In a similar vein, we know little about how the social safety net shapes the quality of paternal relationships with children. Most research on how the safety net affects parents has focused on single mothers; similar attention should be devoted to understanding how such policies shape the extent and quality of unmarried fathers' involvement with their children.

The first generation of welfare reform research relied on random-assignment welfare waiver experiments and studies of welfare leavers immediately following PRWORA. These approaches have been criticized for a lack of external validity because they did not match the actual policies implemented under PRWORA (in the case of the welfare waiver experiments), or for not accounting for individual-level selection into or out of program participation (in the case of welfare leaver studies) (Grogger & Karoly 2005, Miller & Zhang 2012). More recent research on the effects of welfare reform policy has utilized federal- or state-level policy changes—such as state-level changes in TANF generosity or federal or state EITC expansions—to assess program impacts. This strategy offers better external validity than the welfare waiver experiments, and it (mostly) solves the problem of individual-level endogeneity found in the welfare leaver studies. At the same time, studies of state-level policy change present a different methodological concern—that policy change is correlated with changes in other safety net programs, or with contemporaneous changes in the economy or the demographic makeup of the population. Results using state policy change may be biased if these other sources of change are not explicitly accounted for in the models. Given the sheer scale of policy and economic change that occurred during the 1990s and 2000s, it is often difficult to isolate the effects of changes in a particular policy that occurred during that time period.

Recent scholarship has also revealed the growth in deep poverty and extreme poverty, as families excluded from the cash safety net have been left to rely more on in-kind benefits and informal coping strategies to get by on very little (Edin & Shaefer 2015). The levels of cash income in these households are so low that scholars have begun tracking them with indicators used to track poverty in the developing world. The recent discovery of extreme poverty among social scientists has also been accompanied by evidence of troubling indicators of growing material hardship among the poorest households. Beyond these basic indicators of hardship, scholars have much to learn about how the growth of very low incomes has affected family functioning and child well-being.

A final significant shift concerns the continued evolution of social safety net programs at the state level, which has resulted in stark geographic inequality of the safety net. States have always had some leeway to modify program requirements and administration, but this trend has escalated since the 1990s. Federal policy shifted from federal entitlements under AFDC to state block grants under TANF, giving states significant leeway to make their TANF benefits less generous and spend block grant dollars on things other than cash aid. Many states responded by shifting federal TANF dollars away from cash aid for the neediest. Similarly, states are increasingly able

to submit waivers to the SNAP program to alter eligibility for nutritional assistance, sometimes in ways that made the program more generous than national standards and/or that put stricter work requirements in place. Finally, some states have layered their own state EITCs on top of the federal refund, resulting in even larger tax refunds to the working poor, but offerings vary considerably across states. Uncovering the continuing evolution of social safety net programs and their role in generating vastly unequal life chances across states is an important topic for future research along outcomes ranging from socioeconomic mobility to mortality.

Research on the social safety net has advanced in recent years with novel data collection and linkages. Although safety net research has always drawn from a variety of data sources including administrative records, longitudinal surveys, and in-depth qualitative interviews, there is growing concern about bias in self-report data on program participation; for example, recent estimates suggest underreporting of SNAP participation rates by as much as 50% in large national surveys like the CPS and ACS (Meyer & Mittag 2015). Scholars have developed microsimulation tools to correct for underreporting, and researchers have increasingly turned to administrative data to measure program participation and important social, health, and economic outcomes. Future efforts to make such linkages more accessible to researchers while maintaining confidentiality will have an enormous payoff for understanding the short- and longer-term effects of the social safety net on household well-being. At the same time, however, many family dynamics and adaptive strategies that are important for child well-being—such as living arrangements, child custody, and parental resource transfers—exist beyond the purview of administrative records and recent efforts have aimed to collect more fine-grained, longitudinal data to capture these inter- and intrahousehold dynamics.

Social safety net research has typically taken either a macro-level view—describing overall trends and patterns at the national level—or a micro-level view, focusing on the consequences of a particular program for individuals and families. In this review, we have highlighted the utility of research approaches that consider the meso level—the entire bundle of cash and near-cash social safety net programs—and its heterogeneous consequences for household well-being. Future research on the continued evolution of this bundle of social safety net programs is crucially needed to inform, for example, how the safety net has influenced other important social processes such as social inclusion, class conflict, racial and gender inequality, and broader systems of stratification in our national welfare state. Such inquiries would reveal how safety net transformations intersect with other forms of institutional and political change to collectively shape families, communities, and nations.

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